WINDS OF CHANGE
Protesters at Jantar Mantar, New Delhi, Jul. 22

found loyalty, emotional honesty and clarity ranking unusually high among what this generation wants from relationships. Ganguly says they no longer wait for politicians, parents or institutions to speak for them—they have built their own platforms and increasingly expect to be present when decisions are made rather than be briefed on them afterwards. Their frustration, she argues, comes from a widening distance



"Youth today do not want a seat at the back of the room. They want to be where decisions are made and help shape what comes next"

– ANNA NATH GANGULY
Associate Professor, Political Science, Amity University Noida

between values and reality: limited jobs, nepotism and eroding accountability.

"This generation doesn't fear authority. They thrive on authenticity and transparency," says Praneet Kaur, a trauma-informed counselling psychologist. "They are not scared of outcomes; they just know that this is the only way forward." Their impatience is not reserved solely for the government. Gen Z has turned the same scrutiny on Bollywood, sportspersons and influencers, demanding to know why their role models have stayed silent. For a generation that has decided speaking up is not optional but a right, that silence is a betrayal from the very people they look up to. ■

—Suhani Singh, Sonali Acharjee and Shelly Anand

VOX POP

"THEIR FIGHT IS OUR FIGHT"



MUAN | 26
Corporate professional based in Gurugram, originally from Manipur

If students are forced onto the streets to fight for their future, the rest of society has a responsibility to stand with them. I am here to stand with them. But fixing recruitment exams alone is not enough. The government must also strengthen school education and bridge the growing divide between government and private schools.

only seven per cent apprenticeship cells. HECI was proposed but never legislated. Research funding remains thin.

The clearest measure of a government's priorities is how it spends its money. In nominal terms, the Union education ministry's allocation has risen from Rs 85,010 crore in 2018-19 to Rs 1.22 lakh crore in the 2025-26 Revised Estimate and Rs 1.39 lakh crore in the 2026-27 Budget Estimate. As a share of the Union budget, however, it has fallen from 4.6 per cent in 2013-14 to about 2.5 per cent. Combined Centre-state spending on education is estimated at 4.1 per cent of GDP, below the NEP target of six per cent. The shift in priorities is equally striking. In 2013-14, education and health together received 6.5 per cent of the Union budget, against 1.8 per cent for roads and highways. Twelve years later, education and health account for 4.5 per cent, while roads and highways receive a healthy 5.8 per cent.

RISE OF THE COCKROACH PARTY

This accumulation of failures provided the fuel for the anger. The CJP gave it a name, an identity and an outlet. Ironically, the party was born not in direct opposition to the Modi government, but in response to a remark attributed to the Chief Justice of India. On May 15, while hearing a contempt plea concerning fake law degrees, CJI Surya Kant called such people "parasites of society" and likened unemployed youngsters drifting into journalism, social media and RTI activism to cockroaches who "start attacking everyone". Taking to social media platform X, Abhijeet Dipke, a 30-year-old political communications strategist, asked: what if all the cockroaches came together? The following day, he launched the CJP. On May 16, the CJI clarified that he had been misquoted.

It made little difference. Within 78 hours, the CJP's Instagram account had crossed three million followers. Within five days, it reached 10 million, overtaking the BJP's official handle and, by May 22, it had touched 20 million. #MainBhiCockroach trended nationally. The CJP held its first Delhi protest at Jantar Mantar on June 6, after Dipke returned from the United States. The movement soon spread to Maharashtra, West Bengal, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, Kerala, Karnataka and Goa.

The arrival of Sonam Wangchuk at the protest site became the turning point. The Ladakhi engineer, climate activist and education reformer began an indefinite hunger strike at Jantar Mantar on June 28, demanding Pradhan's resignation and an overhaul of the examination system. His fast gave fresh emotional momentum to what had begun as a protest against examination leaks. In a pre-dawn operation on July